SCHOOL OF MANAGEMENT

AIW362R INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS STRATEGY

SEMESTER 1

ACADEMIC SESSION 2025/2026

TITLE OF ASSIGNMENT:
A CASE STUDY OF CANADA GOOSE: LEVERAGING RESOURCES AND CAPABILITIES FOR COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE

DATE OF SUBMISSION:
2026/1/9

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1.0 Introduction

1.1 Company Profile and Industry Context

Founded in Toronto in 1957 as Metro Sportswear Ltd., Canada Goose has grown from a small manufacturer of functional apparel into a globally recognized brand in high-performance luxury outerwear. The brand's core identity is rooted in its conquest of extreme environments: the Expedition parka (nicknamed “Big Red”) developed for scientists at McMurdo Station in Antarctica in the 1980s, and the gear that helped the first Canadians summit Mount Everest in 1982, established its reputation for "professional-grade cold-weather protection." Since current CEO Dani Reiss took the lead in the 1990s, the brand has made a clear strategic commitment to "Made in Canada," still operating seven factories in Canada, deeply integrating high-quality materials with exquisite craftsmanship. This brand DNA, supported by superior performance, local manufacturing, and a rich heritage, has successfully positioned it in the luxury market, with products priced significantly higher than ordinary functional clothing (Canada Goose, 2025).

Since the late 20th century, the global apparel industry has gradually developed a mainstream development logic centered on "cost efficiency" and "scale expansion." In pursuit of ultimate optimization, brands generally outsource or offshore production to regions with low labor costs (such as Bangladesh, Vietnam, and China in Asia), leveraging local industrial clusters and economies of scale. This globalized supply chain model has become the industry standard, enabling most companies to maintain low prices, achieve rapid turnover, and compete in the global market (McKinsey & BoF, 2021).

However, Canada Goose's strategic choice stands in stark contrast. While the industry mainstream has been offshored, the company, under the leadership of CEO Dani Reiss, has,

since the 1990s, adhered to its "Made in Canada" commitment. Adhering to "Made in Canada" means that Canada Goose has proactively accepted the cost disadvantages brought about by North America's high labor costs and compliance standards, a necessary prerequisite for its high-end pricing. However, this pricing is far more than just covering costs; the underlying logic is that the brand transforms this cost structure into a value proposition about quality, craftsmanship, and transparency, thereby solidifying its position as a true luxury brand in the minds of consumers.

1.2 The Core Strategic Choice and Dilemma

Canada Goose's "Made in Canada" strategy is the cornerstone of all its business decisions, but also a choice fraught with inherent tension. It is not a neutral declaration of place of production, but a proactively constructed and costly value commitment. This commitment is specifically reflected in three aspects:

Firstly, complete control over ultimate quality and craftsmanship. By internalizing production in its own factories, Canada Goose can directly manage the entire process from selecting top-grade down to extreme environment sewing tests, which is essentially a profound manifestation of vertical integration. According to Arcuri & Giolli (2022), vertical integration refers to the strategic behavior of companies extending upstream to acquire supplier functions, with the core purpose of achieving complete control over key links in the supply chain. By internalizing production links that previously relied on external cooperation, companies can more directly control raw materials, production processes, and quality standards, thereby truly implementing end-to-end management from source to finished product.

Secondly, providing undisputed supply chain transparency and ethical guarantees to comply with stringent North American regulations and respond to modern consumers' inquiries about sustainability and ethical production. Fraj and Martinez explicitly pointed out that "consumers are increasingly interested in purchasing eco-fashion, but they lack corresponding information, as a result, providing sufficient information in terms of eco-materials, sustainable manufacturing, green distribution, and green retailing, helps eco-products to be promoted better among consumers" (as cited in Shen, 2014, p. 4).

Thirdly, it involves building an unbreakable country-of-origin narrative. Canada Goose, through the "Made in Canada" label, successfully leveraged the classic country-of-origin effect by projecting Canada's image of a pristine, harsh natural environment and reliable craftsmanship into consumers' minds. The strength of this effect has been empirically supported: research has found that country-of-origin image is a key variable predicting consumers' intention to purchase products from a particular country (e.g., for US products, $\beta=0.48$, $p<0.01$) (Rezvani et al., 2012). Similarly, shaping and reinforcing the perception of "Canada" as a pure and reliable country of origin is expected to directly increase consumers' willingness to purchase and their tendency to pay a higher premium. However, this value promise also directly led to its core business dilemma: a strategic paradox comprised of a "high-cost structure" and "vulnerability." Insisting on local manufacturing permanently burdened it with fixed costs far exceeding the industry average, which had to be absorbed through high product premiums (priced between $295 and $1,695 in textbooks) (Peng, 2022).

Therefore, the brand's market success heavily relied on consumers consistently recognizing its "story" and being willing to pay a premium. This made it particularly vulnerable during periods of economic fluctuation or consumer tightening—its costs could not be flexibly

reduced, and high-priced products were most likely to be postponed by consumers. Essentially, Canada Goose's success was built on its ability to consistently convince the world that the value represented by its products always exceeded its costs.

1.3 Research Question and Analytical Framework

Based on the aforementioned strategic dilemmas, the core question of this study is: How can Canada Goose transform its high-cost disadvantage into a sustainable competitive advantage through its "Made in Canada" strategy?

To answer this question, this paper will systematically evaluate the core resources and capabilities upon which its strategy relies (such as brand heritage, vertically integrated quality control, and country of origin reputation) based on the Resource-Based View (RBV) and utilizing the value chain and VRIO frameworks to determine the source and sustainability of its competitive advantage.

2.0 Resource-Based View (RBV): Basic Inventory

Resource-based perspective, the performance of firms can be partially attributed to the resources that firms possess, and capabilities that firms acquire over time. Peng (2022) suggests that resources and capabilities could be divided into two broad categories of intangible and tangible resources and capabilities. This part gives an elementary listing of the main resources and capabilities of this firm in a rudimentary way.

2.1 Tangible Resources

Physical assets are the resources that can be seen and are rather easy to detect and quantify (Peng, 2022). The manufacturing facilities in Canada are one of the valuable physical assets of the company. Such facilities are one major physical resource that enables the firm to have

direct control on its production. The local production also helps in maintaining consistency in production and elimination of dependency on overseas suppliers.

Besides that, the company has enough financial assets, which allows it to invest in talented workforce, raw materials with high quality, and continuous operation. Good financial resources are especially necessary considering the increased costs of production in a developed economy. This financial ability enables the company to maintain its operation as it keeps supporting long term strategic goals.

2.2 Intangible Resources

In comparison with physical resources, intangible ones are harder to observe and measure, but they can often be more relevant to determine the competitive outcomes (Peng, 2022).

The brand reputation of the firm is one of the intangible resources. The brand today has been identified with reliability, durability, and high quality. This reputation boosts customer confidence and is useful in explaining the top price levels in the marketplace.

A country-of-origin image of Made in Canada is another valuable intangible resource of the firm. The perception of country-of-origin may also affect the judgment of quality of the products by the consumers. In this instance, Canadian manufacturing would usually be associated with the art of craftsmanship, cold weather, and authenticity. This fact reinforces the brand image of the firm and creates a distinction with other competitors whose production depends mostly on offshore production.

The company also enjoys good design capabilities, which is a demonstration of knowledge and experience inculcated in its design teams. This knowledge enables the company to strike the right balance between a functional performance and the aesthetic value in such a way that the company will succeed in satisfying practical as well as lifestyle demands of its customers.

2.3 Capabilities

Whereas resources are what the firm possesses, capabilities are the effectiveness with which the firm utilizes the resources at its disposal (Peng, 2022).

Quality control is one of such abilities. Being able to keep the production processes within the country and in the firm, the company can observe the manufacturing processes very closely and ensure the uniformity of the quality of the products. This feature facilitates reliability of the product and strengthens consumer trust.

The other critical capability is the premium branding capability of the firm. Through its physical and intellectual resources, i.e. domestic production, brand image, and design skills, the company can compress them into a stable high end brand image. This will enable the company to place its products in the upper segment of the market and have a distinct strategic focus.

All in all, the combination of the tangible resources, the intangible resources as well as capabilities of the firm are the basis of strategic positioning of the firm. These aspects form the basis of additional analysis that can be applied to analytical frameworks like the VRIO framework that is presented in the next section.

3.0 Value Chain Analysis of Canada Goose

3.1 The purpose of value chain analysis

This section aims to illustrate through the analysis of the value chain how Canada Goose creates value in its business operations.According to Chapter 3 of the textbook, the value chain refers to a series of activities that add value to products or services, including primary

activities and supporting activities.By analyzing these activities, it can be explained why Canada Goose chose to keep its core production activities within the company rather than outsourcing them to low-cost countries, and how this choice supports its high-end differentiation strategy.

3.2 Main Activities

3.2.1 Inbound Logistics

Canada Goose attaches great importance to the quality of its raw materials, such as high-quality down and fur.These raw materials directly affect the warmth and durability of the products, and they are among the most important factors that consumers consider when purchasing high-end outdoor clothing.By strictly selecting raw materials, Canada Goose is able to maintain consistency in product quality and provide a fundamental support for its high-end brand image.

3.2.2 Production Operations

The most distinctive feature of Canada Goose's value chain is its commitment to manufacturing in Canada itself.Unlike many clothing companies that outsource production to low-cost countries, Canada Goose completes its production with local skilled workers and a strict quality control system.This internal production model helps enterprises better control product quality, enhance production coordination efficiency, and reduce the uncertainties brought about by outsourcing.Keeping key activities within the enterprise helps to develop the enterprise's unique capabilities and enhance its competitive advantage (Ismayilov et al., 2021).

3.2.3 Marketing and Sales

In terms of marketing, Canada Goose clearly positions itself as a high-end, professional and authentic brand."Made in Canada" not only indicates a production method, but also serves as a crucial marketing message, conveying to consumers high quality, exquisite craftsmanship and the national reputation.This high-end positioning enables the company to adopt a high pricing strategy and create a clear distinction from competitors who rely on low-cost production（Kumar & Perepu, 2020).

3.3 Support Activities

3.3.1 Human Resource Management

The production of Canada Goose is highly dependent on skilled workers, and therefore human resource management holds a significant position in its value chain.The company ensures the stability of production quality by providing training to and retaining experienced employees.Human resources are regarded as crucial intangible resources. When enterprises can manage them effectively, they will have a significant impact on long-term competitive advantages.

3.3.2 Technology and Product Design

Canada Goose continues to invest in product design and technological improvements to enhance the functionality and comfort of its products.The design capability not only supports production activities, but also helps enterprises make appropriate adjustments when entering different markets, while maintaining the core characteristics of the brand, thereby enhancing product differentiation.

3.4 Strategic Choices for Internal Production and Outsourcing

Although outsourcing is generally regarded as an effective way to reduce costs, Canada Goose consciously avoids outsourcing its core manufacturing activities.If an enterprise outsources all its key activities, it may lose its strategic control capabilities.For Canada Goose, internal production helps maintain product quality, brand authenticity, and long-term value creation. Therefore, its value chain choice is highly consistent with its high-end strategy and resource foundation（Wernick et al., 2023).

3.5 The Relationship between Value Chain and Competitive Advantage

Overall, the value chain of Canada Goose creates value through high-quality raw materials, internal production, skilled labor, and high-end brand marketing.The main activities and supporting activities are well coordinated with each other, providing a solid foundation for the establishment of the enterprise's competitive advantage, and laying the groundwork for the subsequent application of the VRIO framework to analyze its sustainable competitive advantage.

4.0 VRIO Analysis: Canada Goose's "Made in Canada" Model and Brand as a Sustainable Competitive Advantage

Based on the Resource-Based View (RBV), VRIO analyzes external and internal environments along four dimensions — Value, Rarity, Imitability, and Organization — to determine whether resources and capabilities of a firm can generate sustained competitive advantage. This article examines Canada Goose’s two core strategic resource – its “Made in Canada” production system and its global premium brand and assesses its competitiveness in the global luxury outdoor apparel industry. Research indicates that these two synergistic

assets constitute a resource portfolio that complies with the VRIO framework and enables the Canadian brand to sustain a competitive advantage in this particular market.

4.1 VRIO Analysis of Core Strategic Assets

4.1.1 Value: Creating Customer and Market Value

Functional Absorption of Value and Emotional Delivery of Value: Canada Goose's "Made in Canada" model of production and related resources resulted in a substantial delivery of value for consumers, the company, and the brand. The local production "Made in Canada" model enables the brand to keep tight quality control to provide customers with high-quality, cold weather outerwear easily wearable, even in extreme weather. This leads to optimum product performance; its apparel for the professional outdoors is tested in temperatures as low as -40°C, has a waterproof rating of 20,000 mm, and wind resistance capability of 100 km/h. The feature is so functional that it has a 95 percent customer satisfaction rate and it made up 68 percent of the company's revenue ($1.26 billion) for the 2023 fiscal year. The brand also charges up its products to a status symbol, with jackets costing between $895 and $1,750, pulling in $1.21 billion in global revenue in 2023.

Trade and Operational Value: "Made in Canada" version facilitates tariff volatility risk mitigation under the USMCA (United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement) and its being a top-tier brand supports a gross margin of 64.7%, well above the average for non-luxury outdoors wear. For instance, after releasing its "Sea Mantra" sustainable line, global searches for the brand rose 19% year-on-year, signaling brand-led demand in the market. The "Made in Canada" label taps into the strong positive national perception of fair labour, authenticity guarantees and high standards that Australia enjoys amongst consumers and provides a level of consumer trust and value. The brand's emphasis on quality and local production speaks to

today's consumers desire for responsible manufacturing, helping to further its sustainable and ethical ethos.

4.1.2 Scarcity: Uniqueness Among Competitors

A Rare Production Model: More than 90 per cent of Canada Goose's down jackets are made in its seven factories in Canada, and it even operates dedicated sewing technician training schools. Most players in the industry entrust manufacturing in the low-cost countries to cut down on expenses. In stark contrast, Canada Goose's dedication to "Made in Canada," the use of local production facilities, local suppliers, and a skilled Canadian labor force, is extremely unusual. The Brand has managed to take this method of production and use it in a way which places the Brand on a perfectly premium playing field in relation to its competitors.

Distinctive Brand Equity: The brand's red Arctic logo is over 70% globally recognized especially among the high income population in North America and Europe. Its more than 60 years brand heritage tells a unique story of professional cold-weather gear, that's hard for many others to duplicate. The brand also holds 87 proprietary design patents, making it even more scarce in the high-end outdoor apparel market.

4.1.3 Imitability: High Barriers to Replication

The economies of scale and shell of "Made in Canada": Canada Goose's resources and capabilities are very difficult to imitate mainly because of causal ambiguity, social complexity and path dependence. To duplicate Canada's production system takes big upfront costs. The company says that Canadian manufacturing costs are three to four times higher than those in China and that a skilled workforce is needed to know how to work with down filling and thermal engineering. It is time consuming and costly for rivals to try to imitate

this infrastructure. The firm's longstanding relationships with regional suppliers and adherence to stringent Canadian labor and environmental regulations create additional entry barriers.

The brand's causal ambiguity and path dependence: "Made in Canada" is not purely a production decision, it's also a cultural and branding asset. This brand equity has a path-dependent nature, shaped by its history as a provider of polar expedition gear and many years of steady brand development built around authenticity and Canadian workmanship. The cultural-symbolic value created over years of product placements in films, sponsorship of holidays and endorsements from celebrities is impenetrable to rivals. And its 17 proprietary innovations in thermal design from materials science make the world a colder place to copy for others.

4.1.4 Organizational Utilization: Effectively Leveraging Strategic Assets

Operational Synergy: The Canada Goose structure in terms of the rights and obligations of governance at the board level facilitated the efficient use of its resources and capabilities. The raw material procurement, production, and distribution is integrated within the Canada Goose system, so it is able to make flexible changes in production according to market demand with the vertically integrated manufacturing system. The company devotes 14.7% of its revenues to marketing and 3.5% to product development, thus investing in both sides of the brand/product synergy-enhancing equation.

Global and Local Execution: The company has grown into 124 global retail stores, built a full e-commerce platform, and continues to fine-tune regional market strategies. Its marketing and brand building activities never stopped repeating "Made in Canada" further associating place of production with quality and premium value. In addition, activities that support (such as R&D and logistics) are integrated with the core activities that drive businesses forward, so

that resources can be utilized effectively. Such a strong synergy between the organization and its core resources and capabilities ensures that the company will be able to sustain the competitive advantage offered by the VRIO framework on an on-going basis.

4.2 Conclusion

Both the "Made in Canada" production model and the premium brand of Canada Goose fit the VRIO framework for both aspects drove value for customers and the organization, were rare across competitors, were difficult to replicate, and were supported by the organization's structure and strategy. This unique combination of resources and capabilities allows Canada Goose to sustain a competitive advantage within a highly competitive market and enables it to prosper even in challenging economic conditions worldwide.

5.0 Strategic implications and Conclusion

5.1 Strategic Impacts

Based on the resource-based value (RBV) view and the insight of Chapter 3 "Wise Strategists", the Canada Goose Case provides three key strategic implications for companies committed to building a sustainable competitive advantage.

First of all,intangible assets are the cornerstone of the long-term success of the premium market.Unlike tangible assets (such as production facilities) that can be copied or replaced, Canada Goose's "Made in Canada" reputation, high-quality brand assets and perceived high quality are scarce, difficult to imitate, and deeply rooted in consumers' perception - intangible assets. This is consistent with the core premise of the value view based on resources: the company's competitive advantage comes not only from tangible or financial resources, but

also from unique and irreplaceable intangible assets that create lasting customer value. For other companies - especially those in high-end industries such as luxury goods, outdoor equipment or handicrafts - investing in the construction and protection of intangible assets (such as brand authenticity and ethical production narratives) may have a more far-reaching impact than pursuing short-term cost savings.

Secondly,outsourcing is not a one-size-fits-all strategy. Core activities closely related to value and brand image should be kept internally. Chapter 3 discusses the pros and cons of outsourcing. Canada Goose decided to insist on making it in Canada despite the high cost, which highlights a key principle: activities that directly affect product quality, brand credibility or customer trust are very important and should not be outsourced. By maintaining control over production, the company ensures consistent quality, strengthens its "Made in Canada" commitment, and avoids the strategic risk of its core value proposition being diluted. This means that companies should first analyze their value chains (as analyzed in Section 3 of Chapter 3) to identify activities that are inseparable from competitive advantages - even if the cost is higher, these activities are worth protecting through internal execution.

Third, differentiation through strategic positioning is better than just focusing on cost as a competitive advantage.The success of Canada Goose broke the traditional concept of "low cost = market lead". Instead, the company uses its unique resources (Canadian manufacturing expertise and cold weather product design capabilities) to develop high-end market segments, targeting customers who are willing to pay higher prices for quality, durability and brand logo. This is consistent with the conclusion of the VRIO framework: sustainable competitive advantages come from valuable, scarce and difficult to imitate resources. Canada Goose focuses on its core advantages (high performance, ethical rationality and durable gears),

avoiding the fiercely competitive low-cost market, so as to build a loyal customer base. For strategists, this highlights the importance of the "strategic vision" - focusing on identifying unmet customer needs that match the company's unique resources, rather than simply copying the cost-cutting strategies of competitors.

5.2Potential risks

Although Canada Goose's business model has proven to be effective, there are still some potential loopholes.

First of all, rising domestic costs(such as Canadian labor costs, raw material costs such as fur and feathers) may put pressure on profit margins, especially if companies hesitate to further raise prices because they are worried about alienating price-sensitive high-end consumers.

Secondly,the scale restrictions of domestic production may limit global expansion- Unlike competitors outsourced to low-cost countries, the production capacity of Canada Goose is closely linked to domestic facilities, which may make it difficult for it to meet the surge in emerging markets.

Third,the threat of imitation - Although according to the VRIO framework, it is difficult to completely copy the model of Canada Goose due to causal ambiguity and organizational embedding, competitors may try to imitate its narrative of "domestic production" or "high quality", which will erode the scarcity of the company's resources in the long run.

5.3 Conclusion

On the strategic question raised at the beginning - Can Canada Goose's "Made in Canada + High Cost + Premium" model maintain its competitive advantage? Resource-based view (RBV) and the VRIO framework provide positive answers. By using tangible resources (domestic production facilities, financial capital) and intangible assets (brand reputation, country of origin assets) to support core value chain activities, the company has established a valuable, scarce and difficult-to-image resource portfolio, which is effectively organized and utilized through operation and brand strategy. This combination of resources translates into a sustainable competitive advantage, because consumers still prioritize quality, authenticity and brand fit over cost.

For strategists, the Canada Goose case reinforces the core message of Chapter 3: companies make themselves different due to resource heterogeneity (the first core problem based on the resource perspective), and their success in the international market depends on the company's use of its specific resources and capabilities (plus the factor of luck). In order to maintain its competitive advantage, Canada Goose needs to continuously protect its intangible assets (for example, respond to consumers' concerns about fur use by strengthening ethical production practices), optimize internal operations to reduce cost pressure, and use strategic vision to adapt to changing market demand (for example, using sustainable materials and Participate in digital marketing). Ultimately, this case shows that even high-cost business models can achieve lasting success when resources and capabilities are consistent with strategic positioning and organizational structure.

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